

COLORADO FIELD ORNITHOLOGISTS - SIGHT RECORD FORM

(PLEASE PRINT OR TYPE. ATTACH PHOTOGRAPHS, DRAWINGS AND ADDITIONAL PAGES AS NECESSARY)

SPECIES: Glaucous-winged Gull Larus Glaucescens
(Common Name) (Scientific Name)

DATE(S) OF OBSERVATION: March 22, 2000

NUMBER OF BIRDS SEEN: One SEX: Unknown PLUMAGE: 1st Basic

EXACT LOCATION: west side of Horseshoe Lake, visible from Ptarmigan Run

COUNTY: Larimer NEAREST TOWN: Loveland ELEVATION: 5200'

LENGTH OF OBSERVATION: 45 minutes TIME(S) OF OBSERVATION: 3:45 to 4:30pm

OTHER OBSERVERS WHO SAW THE BIRD(S) WITH YOU:
None

OTHER OBSERVERS WHO INDEPENDENTLY SAW THE BIRD(S):
Joe Mammoser, Fort Collins

LIGHT CONDITIONS (QUALITY; DIRECTION RELATIVE TO BIRD(S); POSITION):

Mostly cloudy, sun was directly behind me during the entire observation; I had excellent looks at this bird through the scope as there were no heat waves or bright sunlight to contend with.

OPTICAL EQUIPMENT USED:

90X Questar scope, 10X binoculars

DISTANCE FROM BIRD (ESTIMATED UNLESS OTHERWISE NOTED): 150 yards

WAS BIRD PHOTOGRAPHED? no IF SO, HAVE YOU SUBMITTED PHOTOS? no

WHO TOOK THE PHOTOGRAPHS? _____

DESCRIBE THE GENERAL AND SPECIFIC HABITAT IN WHICH THE BIRD(S) OCCURRED:

Muddy shoreline of a drawn down lake. Bird also walked in the shallow edge of the lake.

DESCRIBE THE BIRD'S BEHAVIOR (FLYING; FEEDING; HABITS; BEHAVIORS USED IN IDENTIFYING THE SPECIES OR IN SUPPORTING THE IDENTIFICATION):

The bird was observed sitting on the shoreline at first, at rest. It then began to preen, walking along the shore and in shallow water. It did not feed or bathe while I watched, which was until it flew away.

DESCRIBE THE BIRD IN DETAIL. THIS IS THE MOST IMPORTANT PART OF THIS REPORT. INCLUDE THE OVERALL SIZE AND SHAPE AND HOW YOU PLACED THE BIRD IN THE GENERAL GROUP THAT YOU DID. GIVE COMPLETE DETAILS OF PLUMAGE, INCLUDING HEAD, THROAT, UNDERSIDES, NAPE, BACK, WINGS AND TAIL. GIVE PARTICULAR EMPHASIS TO MARKS YOU USED TO IDENTIFY THE BIRD(S). DESCRIBE OTHER DETAILS, SUCH AS COLOR AND SHAPE OF BILL, LEGS, EYE, ETC. THAT WERE IMPORTANT IN MAKING THE IDENTIFICATION. (FILL OUT THIS PORTION EVEN IF PHOTOGRAPHS ARE SUBMITTED; YOU MAY ATTACH ADDITIONAL SHEETS, DRAWINGS, FIELD SKETCHES OR COPY OF FIELD NOTES):

Unmistakably, a larger gull. The bird was in the midst of 250 gulls at first, and gradually walked to an edge of the group where I could observe the field marks. My first clue was the size and coloration of the bird. In this group were Herring (adult and immature), Thayer's (immature), California (adult and immature), and Ring-billed Gulls. This bird was about the same size as the Herring, larger than the Thayer's, and noticeably larger than the CA and Ring-billed. It was not as large as a Glaucous Gull. The body was bulky. The bill was all dark, with no pale base or bi-coloring to it. Bill was narrower than the adjacent Herring Gull for most of its length but equally long or slightly longer, and very slightly wider at the end. It was not stubby like a Thayer's. It was noticeably longer billed than the nearby California Gulls. Eye was dark. The overall plumage coloration was uniformly pale tan and white throughout. There was virtually no contrast between the mantle, wings and tail. The coloration was even and the shades of color differences were irregular. There was no evidence of spangling or the checkered pattern as in Thayer's. Undertail coverts were barred. The only darkish color on this bird was caused by the compression of the wing primaries but this was only a tan color. It was not strikingly white, however, as in Iceland. The underwing was uniformly whitish with no dark areas noted as it preened. Some secondaries were exposed as it rested. The legs were pink. Head was smaller than nearby Herring and rounded. I aged this bird as a first winter based on the all black bill that was not extensively bulbous at the end though it appeared to be full length, uniform coloration of tan and white, and lack of any gray in the mantle.

DESCRIBE BIRD'S CALL OR SONG:

It did not call.

DISCUSS SIMILAR SPECIES AND HOW YOU ELIMINATED THEM:

Glaucous – bill was not massive or bi-colored and size was too small. Head shape was all wrong.

Iceland – size was too large, and the coloration was tannish, not whitish.

Thayer's – even the palest Thayer's would have more brown in the mantle, primaries and secondaries. In first basic Thayer's here would be contrast between them (not uniform coloration) and brown and white spangles in a checkered pattern. Exposed secondaries does not usually occur in Thayer's though this mark is non-diagnostic. Bill was not stubby.

Herring – the even, light tan coloration with whitish underwing is much paler than any plumage of Herring.

Hybrids – This was the possibility that I spent the most time considering but this bird did not have any inconsistencies with a first basic Glaucous-winged Gull. A Nelson's hybrid was in the area earlier in the winter but the size and smaller, all dark bill would rule that out. All the Herring x Glaucous-winged hybrids I have seen photos of have bi-colored bills, a non-uniform appearance with a noticeable contrast between mantle and wings, and at least some darker brown in the primaries and tail.

WHAT IS YOUR PRIOR EXPERIENCE WITH THIS AND SIMILARLY APPEARING SPECIES?

I have seen perhaps 100 of this species on the West Coast but this is the first Glaucous-winged Gull in Colorado.

LIST BOOKS, GUIDES, RECORDINGS OR OTHER SOURCES CONSULTED AND HOW THIS INFLUENCED YOUR IDENTIFICATION (DURING AND AFTER OBSERVATION):

None. These notes are prepared from the observation without any consultation with any books. The field mark related to the exposed secondaries came from a web page.

THIS REPORT WAS MADE FROM NOTES MADE DURING ____ OR AFTER XX OBSERVATION, AND LATER FROM MEMORY XX.

DATE OF WRITTEN REPORT: March 22, 2000

REPORTING OBSERVER: Bill Lisowsky SIGNATURE: 

OBSERVER ADDRESS:

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